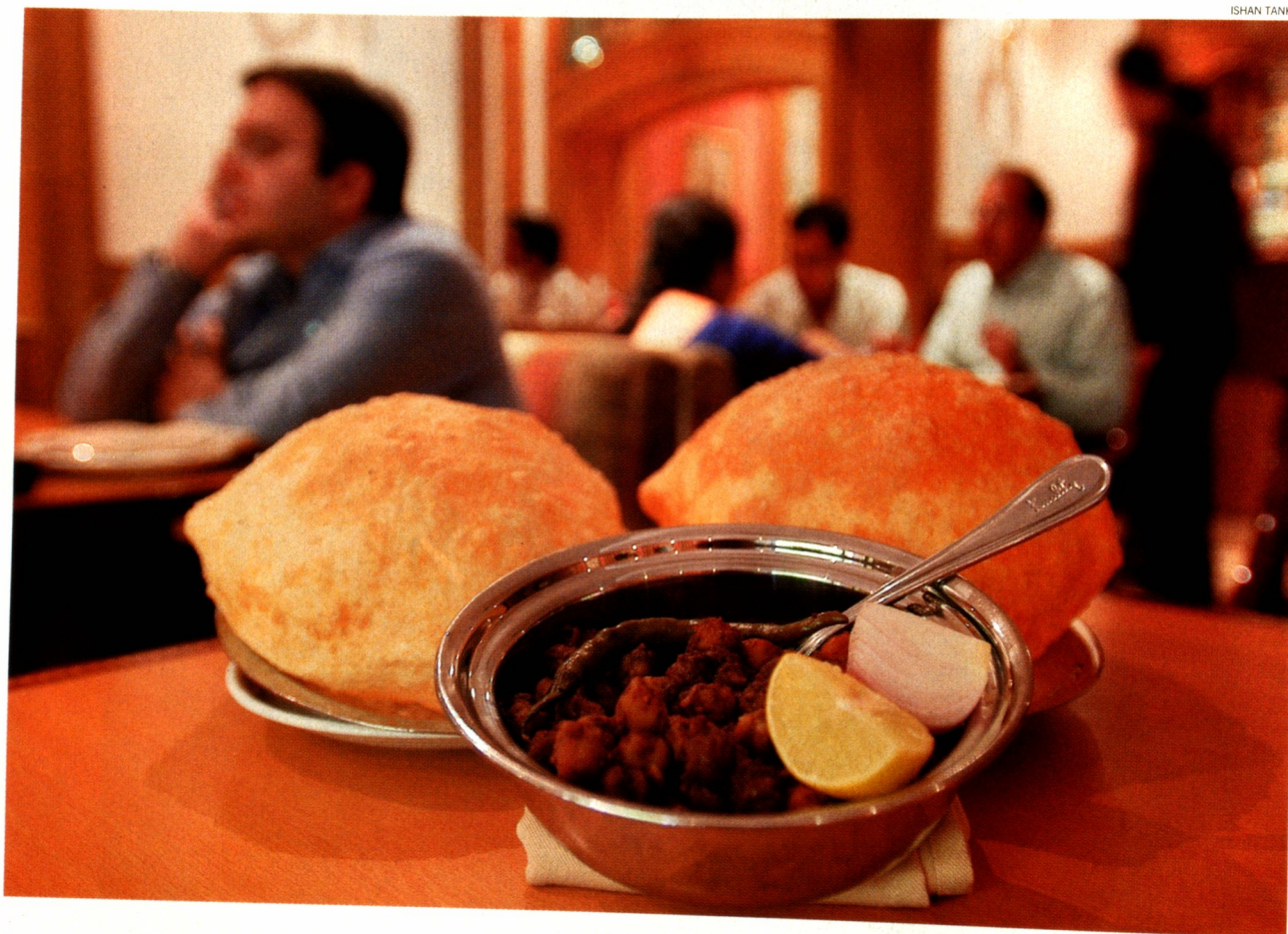


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BEST CHOLE BHATURE ■ KQUALITY, DELHI

Like vada pav is to Mumbai, chole bhature is to most of north India. It's almost a tradition for every alley worth its crumbling haveli to flaunt a favourite stall or even a grimy hole-in-the-wall corner, where piping hot bhaturas, drenched sinfully in oil, are served on little squares of newspaper along with leaf-bowls full of spicy chole. But for generations of Delhiites, Kwality is the only place that counts.

ISHAN TANKI



According to the Lamba family that runs the chain, it's common to see even NRIs drop in for a taste of Kwality's 'Pindi' chole and ask for it to be packed, and carted all the way back to London or New York. The secret probably lies in the masala, which is made in-house. "The dish has been on the menu ever since we set up shop in the 1940s. Over the years, head chefs have been passing on the closely-guarded recipe to their understudies, much like a precious heirloom," says Sunil Lamba, son of P.L. Lamba, who started Kwality. The flagship restaurant in Connaught Place has retained its old-world charm, much like its best-seller, whose price may have zipped skyward, but the taste remains unchanged. "There was a time, when a plate came for less than a rupee, but today the bhaturas cost Rs 40 and a plate of chole comes for Rs 125 plus taxes," says the manager. But Kwality's loyalists are unfazed. While yesteryear actor Nargis would drop in regularly for her plate of chole, these days it's Amar Singh, Arun Jaitley and Rajeev Shukla who do the rounds.

by Newly Paul

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